Political Discontent and Regime Instability

Put abstract here. And here.

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Data Availability Statement

Replication data is available on the Harvard Dataverse [link tbd], and the work's complete revision history is available at https://github.com/fsolt/trust_stability.

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abstract

Introduction

Literature Review

Theory

Data and Measurement

Public political discontent and democratic support

- **Political discontent (PPD)**: latent country-year estimate from the measurement paper (**?**) (DCPO model; (**?**)); 900 posterior draws retained, 0–100 scale.
- **Democratic support**: estimated with the same DCPO model (**?**); 900 paired posterior draws, 0–100.
- Country-years before a country's first actual survey are dropped (the published trim rule); effective window 1988–2019.

Regime-change outcomes

Event codings embody consequential definitional choices, so results can be coding-dependent – we therefore use four canonical datasets rather than one:

1. **V-Dem ERT / Regimes of the World** (**?**): (a) *episode onset*, the first year of a democratization or autocratization episode (a sustained, substantial movement of the electoral-democracy index), with the risk set excluding ongoing-episode years; and (b) *category change*, any move among the four Regimes-of-the-World classes, including the democracy–autocracy boundary crossing.
2. **DD/ACLP** in the Bjornskov–Rode update (**?**), which extends Cheibub–Gandhi–Vreeland coverage to the mid-2020s: democratization and democratic breakdown on the contestation-plus-alternation dichotomy.
3. **Boix–Miller–Rosato** (**?**): the same two events on the Boix-lineage dichotomy (1800–2020).
4. **Geddes–Wright–Frantz** (**?**) regime cases (supplementary: coverage ends 2010, leaving 16 in-sample boundary events).

Table 1: Event overlap across codings, survey-covered sample. Cell entries: captured/eligible share – row-coding events with a counterpart in the column coding (same country, event years within +/-2). Eligible excludes row events outside the column coding's coverage window; only GWF binds (ends 2010, so its column counts row events through 2012).

Event	Coding	Events	Captured by ERT	Captured by DD	Captured by BMR	Captured by GWF
Democratization	ERT	35	–	9/35 (26%)	6/35 (17%)	3/24 (12%)
Democratization	DD	25	9/25 (36%)	–	6/25 (24%)	8/18 (44%)
Democratization	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	6/18 (33%)	–	5/12 (42%)
Democratization	GWF	12	3/12 (25%)	8/12 (67%)	5/12 (42%)	–
Breakdown	ERT	35	–	8/35 (23%)	6/35 (17%)	2/20 (10%)
Breakdown	DD	22	8/22 (36%)	–	10/22 (45%)	4/10 (40%)
Breakdown	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	10/18 (56%)	–	4/10 (40%)
Breakdown	GWF	6	2/6 (33%)	4/6 (67%)	4/6 (67%)	–

Controls

- Log GDP per capita
- GDP growth
- Regional democracy
- Percent Muslim
- Resource dependence
- Prior transitions

- OECD membership
- Income inequality (SWIID 9.8)
- Log population
- Each coding's own regime-age clock (with its square) and transition-history count

Empirical Strategy

1. **Dynamic panel**: to anchor the analysis in the existing literature, we first estimate Claassen's (2020) specification with the democracy *level* as outcome – pooled OLS (panel-corrected SEs) and one-step system GMM.
2. **Discrete-time hazards**: for the regime-event outcomes – plain logit (country-clustered SEs) and Firth penalized likelihood; opinion slopes split by regime type within one pooled hazard (all-regimes and regime-subsample variants alongside); uniform one-year opinion-precedes-outcome timing.
3. **Measurement uncertainty**: method of composition over the 900 posterior draws (estimate = draw mean, SE = draw SD) (**?**; **?**).

Results

Political discontent

- *Destabilizes non-democracies.* Discontent among publics in autocracies raises the hazard that a regime-change episode begins the following year; the effect survives uncertainty propagation.
- *Predicts completed democratization – under turnover-based codings.* The democratization-side effect holds in DD and BMR, the dichotomies built around government turnover; it does not appear in ERT's index-threshold transitions. The event-overlap audit above shows why this is coding-conditional rather than contradictory: the codings record largely distinct "democratization" events, and discontent precedes the turnover type.
- *Does nothing in democracies.* No effect on democratic breakdown under any of the four codings, none on erosion-episode onset, none on annual democracy levels. The "discontent kills democracy" narrative finds no support at any severity level – a null

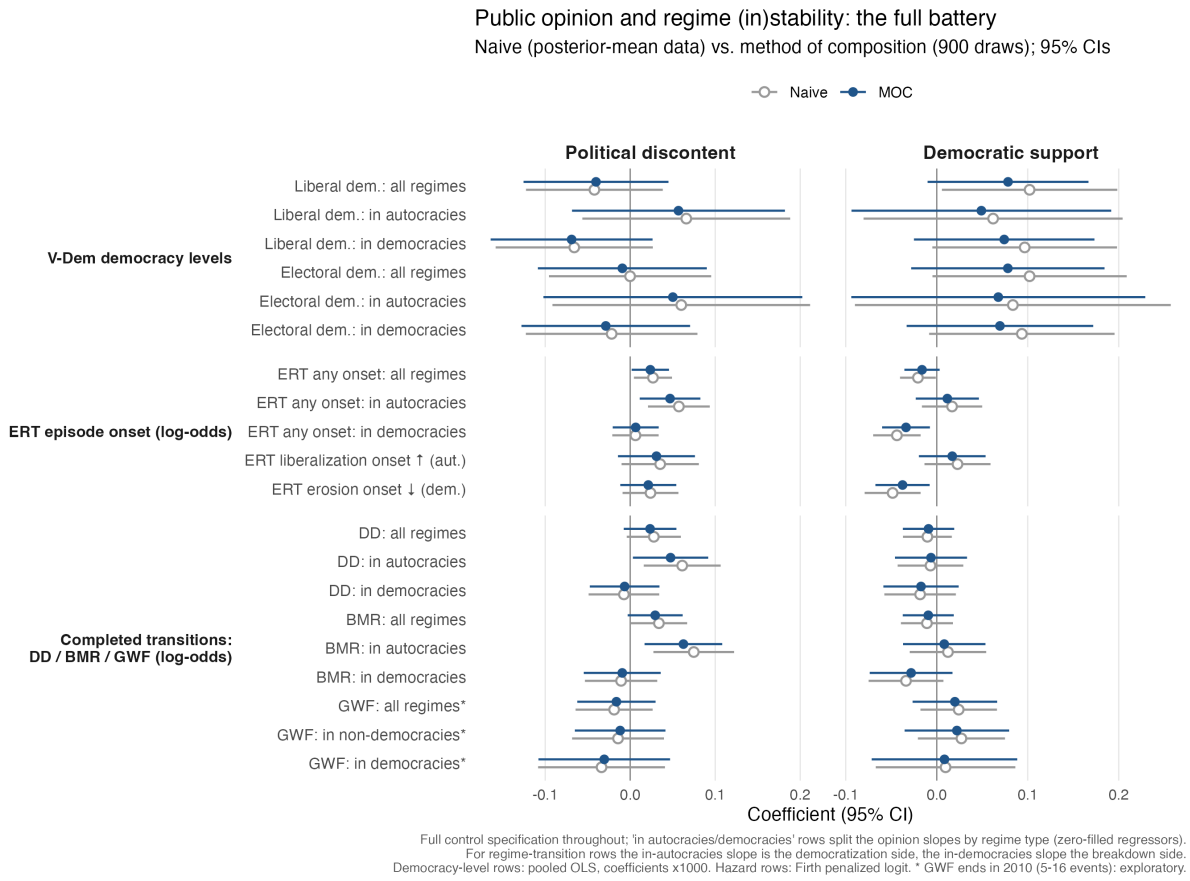


Figure 1: The full battery at a glance: focal coefficients with 95% confidence intervals, naive (posterior-mean data, open grey) vs. method of composition (900 draws, solid blue). Top: pooled-OLS democracy-level models (x1000). Middle: ERT episode-onset hazards (Firth). Bottom: completed regime transitions over each coding's democracy boundary, DD/BMR/GWF (Firth; GWF exploratory, coverage ends 2010). Regime-labeled rows split the opinion slopes by regime type.

replicated across four independent event schemes, not one.

Democratic support

- *Protects democracies at the process-start stage.*
- *Does nothing for autocracies.* The autocracy-side support slope is null in every cell; popular support does not shield non-democratic regimes.
- *Level effects do not survive.* Support's naive-significant associations with annual democracy indices attenuate to marginal or null once measurement uncertainty is propagated, replicating the published pattern.

Public opinion does not move annual democracy levels

Table 2: Public opinion and annual democracy-index change (dynamic panel, full specification). Coefficients x1000. Regime-split system GMM (diagnostics-rejected) and the full battery: appendix.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p
Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.042	(0.305)	-0.040	0.043	(0.355)
Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.102**	(0.038)	0.078+	0.045	(0.083)
Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	System GMM	-0.034	(0.395)	-0.030	0.043	(0.488)
Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	System GMM	0.093	(0.122)	0.058	0.062	(0.348)
Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.066	(0.290)	0.057	0.064	(0.375)
Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.066	(0.163)	-0.069	0.049	(0.156)
Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.062	(0.394)	0.049	0.073	(0.501)
Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.097+	(0.062)	0.074	0.051	(0.143)
Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.000	(0.998)	-0.009	0.051	(0.856)
Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.102+	(0.061)	0.078	0.054	(0.149)
Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	System GMM	-0.007	(0.872)	-0.022	0.055	(0.688)
Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	System GMM	0.090	(0.130)	0.052	0.066	(0.430)
Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.060	(0.437)	0.050	0.078	(0.518)
Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.022	(0.672)	-0.029	0.051	(0.570)
Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.084	(0.345)	0.068	0.082	(0.412)
Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.094+	(0.072)	0.069	0.052	(0.185)

Discontent is null in every valid cell (MOC p = .16–.86). Under the full specification, no opinion variable robustly predicts year-to-year movement in democracy indices. If public opinion matters for regimes, it does not operate through marginal annual changes in democratic quality – motivating the shift to discrete regime events.

Episode onset and completed transitions

Table 3: Public opinion and the onset of V-Dem ERT regime-change episodes (discrete-time hazard, regime-split slopes, full specification). Log-odds per point of the 0-100 opinion scales. Pooled, subsample, and direction-specific variants: appendix.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Logit	0.059***	(0.005)	0.048**	0.021	(0.021)	90
ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Firth	0.057***	(0.002)	0.047**	0.018	(0.010)	90
ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Logit	0.007	(0.644)	0.007	0.014	(0.614)	90
ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Firth	0.006	(0.655)	0.006	0.014	(0.640)	90
ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Logit	0.017	(0.318)	0.012	0.018	(0.504)	90
ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Firth	0.017	(0.320)	0.012	0.018	(0.510)	90
ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Logit	-0.045***	(0.002)	-0.036**	0.014	(0.012)	90
ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Firth	-0.044***	(0.001)	-0.034**	0.013	(0.011)	90

Table 4: Public opinion and completed regime transitions across canonical codings (discrete-time hazard, regime-split slopes, full specification). Log-odds. Pooled variants: appendix.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Logit	0.066**	(0.010)	0.053**	0.025	(0.033)	36
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Firth	0.061***	(0.008)	0.048**	0.023	(0.035)	36
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.006	(0.785)	-0.005	0.024	(0.830)	36
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.007	(0.727)	-0.007	0.021	(0.754)	36
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Logit	-0.006	(0.779)	-0.006	0.021	(0.762)	36
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Firth	-0.007	(0.707)	-0.006	0.020	(0.753)	36
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Logit	-0.019	(0.436)	-0.017	0.025	(0.489)	36
DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Firth	-0.018	(0.361)	-0.017	0.021	(0.411)	36
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Logit	0.080***	(0.002)	0.070***	0.027	(0.010)	31
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Firth	0.075***	(0.002)	0.063***	0.023	(0.007)	31
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.010	(0.682)	-0.008	0.024	(0.739)	31
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.011	(0.622)	-0.009	0.023	(0.685)	31
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Logit	0.013	(0.561)	0.009	0.024	(0.713)	31
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Firth	0.012	(0.566)	0.008	0.023	(0.722)	31
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Logit	-0.035	(0.247)	-0.031	0.029	(0.284)	31
BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Firth	-0.034	(0.107)	-0.028	0.023	(0.224)	31
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in non-democracies	Logit	-0.013	(0.728)	-0.008	0.036	(0.827)	16
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in non-democracies	Firth	-0.014	(0.604)	-0.012	0.027	(0.664)	16
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.034	(0.460)	-0.027	0.047	(0.568)	16
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.034	(0.376)	-0.030	0.040	(0.441)	16
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in non-democracies	Logit	0.032	(0.225)	0.027	0.032	(0.405)	16
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in non-democracies	Firth	0.027	(0.267)	0.022	0.029	(0.450)	16
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in democracies	Logit	0.012	(0.860)	0.011	0.062	(0.860)	16
GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in democracies	Firth	0.010	(0.805)	0.008	0.041	(0.836)	16

Summary and Discussion

Reference

Claassen, Christopher. 2020. "Does Public Support Help Democracy Survive?" *American Journal of Political Science* 64 (1): 118–34.

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Online Supplementary Materials

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